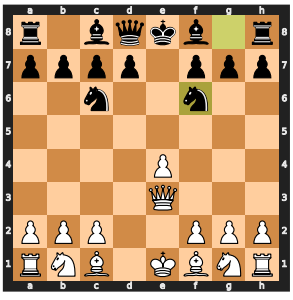
Game 8



Centre Game

Mieses – Capablanca

Berlin, 1913

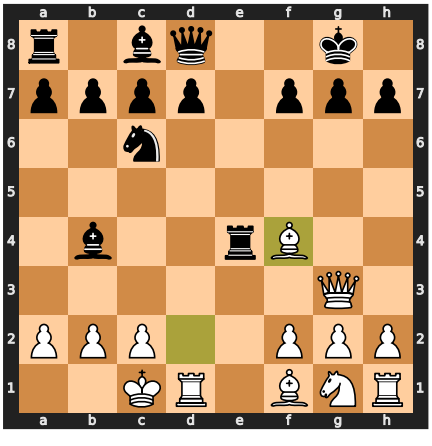
White: J. Mieses Black: J. R. Capablanca

Notes by J. R. Capablanca, from Chess Fundamentals *(1921), which is in the public domain.*
Descriptive notation has been converted to algebraic. Page references are to the book.
Click any move or diagram to open it on Lichess.

1.e4 e5 2.d4 exd4 3.♕xd4 ♘c6 4.♕e3 ♘f6 5.♘c3 ♗b4 6.♗d2 0–0 7.0–0–0 ♖e8

In this position, instead of the text move, 7...d6 is often played in order to develop the Queen's Bishop. My idea was to exert sufficient pressure against the e-pawn to win it, and thus gain a material advantage, which would, at least, compensate whatever slight advantage of position White might have. The plan, I think, is quite feasible, my subsequent difficulties being due to faulty execution of the plan.

8.♕g3 ♘xe4 9.♘xe4 ♖xe4 10.♗f4



10...♕f6

White's threat to regain the Pawn was merely with the idea of gaining time to develop his pieces. Black could have played 10...d6; opening the way for his Queen's Bishop, when would have followed, 11.♗d3 ♖e8 12.♘f3, and White would soon start a powerful direct attack against Black's King. With the text move Black aims at taking the initiative away from White in accordance with the principles laid down in this book.

11.♘h3

If 11.♗xc7 d6; and White's Bishop would be completely shut off, and could only be extricated, if at all, with serious loss of position. The text move aims at quick development to keep the initiative.

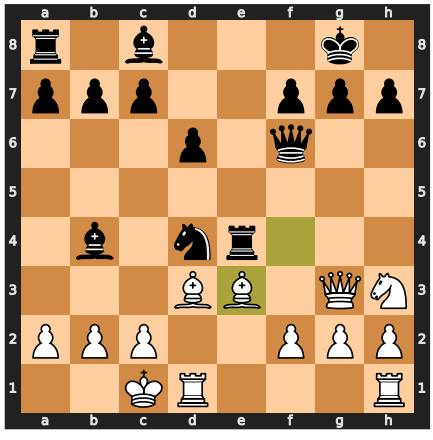
11...d6

This now is not only a developing move, but it also threatens to win a piece by ♗xh3.

12.♗d3 ♘d4

This complicates the game unnecessarily. 12...♖e8; was simple, and perfectly safe.

13.♗e3



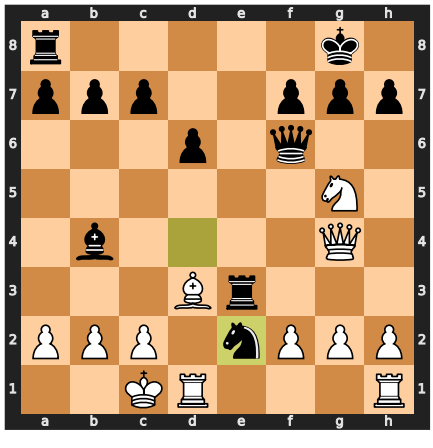
13...♗g4

This is a serious mistake. The position was most interesting, and though in appearance dangerous for Black, not so in reality. The right move would have been 13...♖g4, when we would have 14.♗xd4 ♖xd4 15.c3 ♗xc3 16.bxc3 ♖g4 17.♕e3 (best), 17...♕xc3+ 18.♗c2 ♕xe3+ 19.fxe3 ♖xg2, and Black has the best of the game with four Pawns for a Knight, besides the fact that all the White Pawns are isolated.

14.♘g5! ♖xe3

There was nothing better.

15.♕xg4! ♘e2+

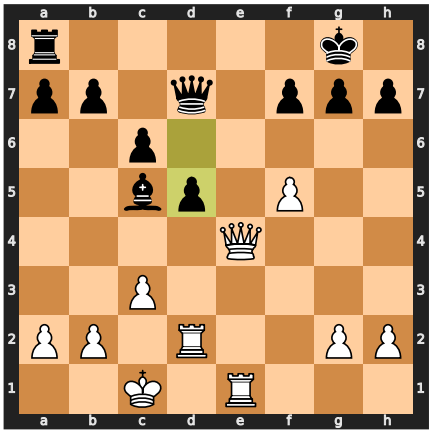


16.♗xe2! ♖xe2 17.♘e4! ♖xe4 18.♕xe4 ♕g5+ 19.f4 ♕b5 20.c3 ♗c5 21.♖he1 ♕c6

22.♖d5

22.♕xc6 would have given White a decided advantage, enough to win with proper play. Mieses, however, feared the difficulties of an ending where, while having the exchange, he would be a Pawn minus. He preferred to keep the Queens on the board and keep up the attack. At first sight, and even after careful thought, there seems to be no objection to his plan; but in truth such is not the case. From this point the game will gradually improve in Black's favour until, with the exchange ahead, White is lost.

22...♕d7 23.f5 c6 24.♖d2 d5



My plan for the moment is very simple. It will consist in bringing my Bishop around to f6. Then I shall try to paralyse White's attack against my King by playing ...h6, and also prevent White from ever playing g5. Once my King is safe from attack I shall begin to advance my Queen's side Pawns, where there are four to three; and that advantage, coupled with the enormous attacking power of my Bishop at f6, will at least assure me an even chance of success.

25.♕f3 ♗e7 26.♖de2 ♗f6 27.♕h5 h6 28.g4 ♔h7!

To prevent 29.h4, which I would answer with 29...g6, winning the Queen. It can now be considered that my King is safe from attack. White will have to withdraw his Queen via h3, and Black can use the time to begin his advance on the Queen's

side.

29.♔b1 ♖d8 30.♖d1 c5

Notice that, on assuming the defensive, White has placed his Rooks correctly from the point of view of strategy. They are both on white squares free from the possible attack of the Black Bishop.

31.♕h3 ♕a4

This gains time by attacking the Rook and holding the White Queen at h3 for the moment, on account of the g-pawn. Besides, the Queen must be in the middle of the fray now that the attack has to be brought home. White has actually more value in material, and therefore Black must utilise everything at his command in order to succeed.

32.♖ed2 ♕e4+ 33.♔a1 b5

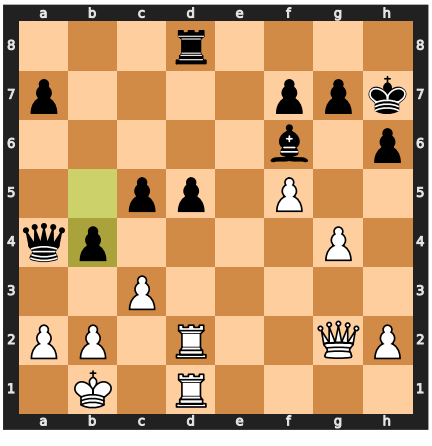
threatening ...b4; which would open the line of action of the Bishop and also secure a passed Pawn.

34.♕g2 ♕a4

indirectly defending the d-pawn, which White cannot take on account of ♕xd1+.

35.♔b1 b4

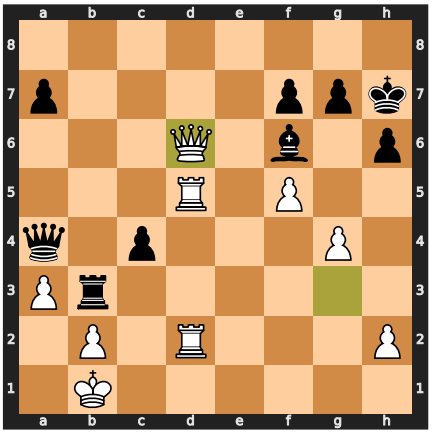
The attack increases in force as it is gradually brought home directly against the King. The position now is most interesting and extremely difficult. It is doubtful if there is any valid defence against Black's best play. The variations are numerous and difficult.



36.cxb4 ♕xb4

Black has now a passed Pawn, and his Bishop exerts great pressure. White cannot very well play now 37.♖xd5 because of 37...♖xd5 38.♖xd5 ♗xb2; and White could not take the Bishop because ♕e4+ would win the Rook, leaving Black a clear passed Pawn ahead.

37.a3 ♕a4! 38.♖xd5 ♖b8 39.♖1d2 c4 40.♕g3 ♖b3 41.♕d6



41...c3

41...♗xb2 would also win, which shows that White's game is altogether gone. In these cases, however, it is not the prettiest move that should be played, but the most effective one, the move that will make your opponent resign soonest.

42.♖c2 cxb2 43.♖d3 ♕e4! 44.♖d1 ♖c3 Resigns.

Of course White must play 45.♕d2, and Black then plays 45...♖xa3.